

The Singing Spring

The sunlit hills of Greece roll down to a bright blue sea, dotted with olive groves, white marble columns, and little towns where everyone knows your name. High above, hidden in the clouds of Mount Olympus, the gods watch over the world, and the hills are full of wonders: riddling sphinxes, kindly centaurs, shy satyrs, and nymphs who sing by the springs. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who keeps a cool head, asks good questions, and stands by a friend. The grandest deeds are done by being brave and kind and full of ideas. Even a fearsome guardian, met with courage and a fair word, often turns out to be lonelier than it is wicked.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.*

Before you begin

For as long as anyone could remember, the Singing Spring had sung high in the hills, and its song had kept every well in the Olive Town cool and brimming. Then, one grey morning, the song simply stopped. The wells sank low. The olive leaves hung limp and thirsty, and the whole valley felt as if it were holding its breath.

Old Daphne, keeper of the olive grove, called the two of you to her side. "You have bright ideas and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more up there than any sword. Will you climb the hill and wake the spring?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a ball of golden thread, a honey cake wrapped in a leaf, and a small lyre worn smooth with playing. "Remember," she said, "in these hills we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."

★ *What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Imagination, Courage, or Heart?*

Stop 1 The Riddle Gate

The road climbed into the sun, and at the top stood a tall gate of white marble. On its warm steps lay a sphinx, her body a lion's, her wings folded gold, her face calm and curious. She watched you with the patience of someone who has all the time in the world.

"None may pass," she said, "until they answer my riddle." There was no cruelty in it. If anything, she looked pleased to have visitors who might actually think.

★ *Will you listen closely and puzzle it out together? A brave, thoughtful guess is welcome too. What do you try?*

When your answer came, the sphinx dipped her great wings and drew the gate aside. "Well thought," she said, almost smiling, and let you through.

Stop 2 The Winding Maze

Beyond the gate the path split, and split again, into a maze of old stone walls where every turning looked exactly like the last. One wrong choice and you might wander until dark.

A goat-legged satyr swung up onto a wall, grinning. It was Bramble, who loved a traveller and a good joke in equal measure. He hummed a tune and tipped his head down one shadowed lane.



How will you keep from losing your way? You carry a ball of golden thread, and Bramble seems willing to help. What is your plan?

By tying the thread at the entrance and letting it trail behind you, every step became a step you could undo. The maze could not trap a hero with a thread, and soon you stepped out into the long golden light of evening.

Stop 3 The Lonely Giant

And there, at last, was the spring. But a giant sat squarely in front of it: one enormous eye, two folded arms, and a face set hard as the cliff behind him. Your heart thumped. He looked, for a moment, like the end of the adventure.

Then he sniffed. And you understood. He was not angry. He was lonely. No traveller had ever stayed to speak with him, and the long silence had made him gruff.



This was never a fight. What kindness could you show him? You have a honey cake to share. You could ask his name, or simply tell him that he is not alone. What do you do?

When you offered your kindness, the giant's huge eye brimmed over, and he wiped it with the back of one enormous hand. "You stayed," he whispered, as though he could hardly believe it. "You are my friends." And he shuffled, very gently, aside.

The Spring Sings Again

You stood at the edge of the quiet water and lifted the little lyre. The tune you played was simple and a touch wobbly, but it came straight from the heart, and that was all the spring had been waiting for.

The surface trembled. Up through the spray rose the Singing Nymphs, laughing, their voices weaving into a song so bright it seemed to lift the whole hillside. The spring leapt back to life, and far below, every well in the Olive Town brimmed cool and clear once more.

High on cloud-wrapped Olympus, kind Athena looked down and smiled. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your ideas, with your courage, and above all with your kindness. Well done, heroes of the Sunlit Hills.

The Singing Spring: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a braver tale than some, but good ideas and kindness still win every time, and no one is ever truly hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Olive Town.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Heart** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a ball of string for the golden thread, a small cake or token for the honey cake, and anything at all for a lyre. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**.

When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Heart together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed.

Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. In these hills, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
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1	A friendly satyr gives you one free hint.
2	You find your courage again, and take back one energy star.
3	A favourable wind, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	Chiron the centaur passes by and nods kindly. All is well.
5	An olive branch for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A burst of birdsong, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

The Lonely Cyclops at the spring is the "foe", but he is no villain. He is a giant who has been alone too long. The tale is won not by beating him but by befriending him, and then by waking the Singing Nymphs with a tune. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Singing Spring: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward fresh ideas and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Riddle Gate (Normal)

The challenge. The Riddle Sphinx will not open the gate until the players answer her riddle. She is fair and patient, and she enjoys a good thinking face.

The riddle. Read it aloud: *"I have roots that nobody sees. I am taller than the tallest trees. Up, up, up I go, and yet I never grow. What am I?"* The answer is **a mountain** (think of Olympus rising above you).

Intended solution. This is a thinking challenge of Imagination and a little Vocabulary. Let the children talk it through together. The sphinx accepts the right answer, and because she is kind, she also accepts a brave, thoughtful guess.

Fallback. If they are stuck, the sphinx offers a clue ("You can see me from your town, and the gods live on my head"), or Bramble the satyr whispers the answer from behind a rock. A guess made bravely still opens the gate.

Stop 2: The Winding Maze (Normal)

The challenge. Beyond the gate is a maze of stone walls where every path looks the same. The players must find their way through without getting lost.

Intended solution. This is a Spatial and Logic moment. The good idea is to use the **golden thread**: tie one end at the entrance and unspool it as you go, so you can always retrace your steps and never walk the same wrong path twice. Marking each turn, or asking **Bramble the Satyr** for a hint, works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have Bramble pop up and point the way with a joke, or let them spend an energy star to "remember" the route. Getting through with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Lonely Cyclops (Hard, then no roll)

The challenge. A huge one-eyed giant sits in front of the spring with his arms folded. He looks fearsome, and the players may feel this is a fight. It is not.

Intended solution. This is a Heart and Courage moment. The giant is simply lonely; nobody ever visits him. Any genuine kindness works: sharing the **honey cake**, asking his name, telling him he is not alone, inviting him to be a friend. When the children are kind, he moves aside with happy tears. Then they wake the spring by playing the **little lyre**, and the **Singing Nymphs** rise and sing.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or want to "win" by force, have the giant sniffle and ask, very quietly, "Are you scared of me too?" A single kind word melts him. The moment the players try any tune at all, the nymphs wake and the water sings.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the spring sings, every well in the Olive Town fills again, the giant has friends at last, and kind **Athena** smiles down from the mountain. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.